Democratising Investment

FROM BEING THE 28TH employee at Kotak Mahindra Bank when it was an NBFC (non-banking financial company) to witnessing its steady rise as a firm with an over-100,000-strong team and which bestrides the world of personal finance, investment banking, life insurance and wealth management like a colossus, Shanti Ekambaram has played a pivotal role in this transformation. Currently serving as a whole-time director (from November 2022) responsible for treasury, digital and other functions, including corporate social responsibility (CSR) and environmental social governance (ESG), Shanti is now focused on building the brand Kotak. No wonder, she is the person behind Kotak's branding in *Kaun Banega Crorepati*.

However, the achievement she treasures the most dates back to 1999, when she introduced to India the global practice of bookbuilding—where an underwriter determines share prices in an IPO—thus challenging the prevailing concept of fixed prices. Despite scepticism about India's potential as a capital market, Shanti led Kotak Mahindra Capital Company to become India's No. 1 investment bank. "There was not one soul who thought we could pull it off," she says.

ACCOMPLISHMENT

She has had a leading role in building the Kotak brand and in its emergence as a market leader in financial/ investment services

Always one to embrace new challenges, Shanti took over the retail business after working in wholesale banking for 24 years. "I did not know what retail was," she confesses, "but that enabled me to start with the basics—what does the customer want?"

Soon after demonetisation in November 2016, Shanti and her team began work on an online savings account they named 811—the date of demonetisation—to enable customers to access their savings digitally. From a seven-day process, account-opening was reduced to five minutes. "We launched it on March 29, in just three months; the next competitor came 11 months later," she says with a sense of pride.

A trained Bharatanatyam dancer, Shanti maintains work-life balance by going on treks in the mountains. A consummate team player, she mentions her colleagues in Kotak as her "biggest inspiration". Her mantra for success? "Having conviction and then going for brute execution." ■

–Sonal Khetarpal



Shanti Ekambaram, *61*

Whole-time Director, Kotak Mahindra Bank

MILIND SHELTE

WHAT WOMEN NEED

"Be confident. Even if you are the only woman in a room with 20 men, if you believe in something, express it confidently. Step out of your comfort zone and don't be content—always aspire for more"

↘ FOOTLOOSE IN NYC

Loves walking in Manhattan with coffee in hand. Trekking in the mountains comes a close second

↘ FAVOURITE FOOD

Dal-chawal, cheese, dark chocolate with almonds